

NOTRUMP OPENINGS

These 100 Deals are all about hands that are either opened 1NT or 2NT, or perhaps overcalled 1NT or 2NT. Some of them end up being played at a Notrump contract, but others are played with a trump suit.

The proficiency level for the Deals is Intermediate/Advanced, both in the Bidding and Declarer play.

ABOUT THE DEALS

Each Deal shows only your hand during the Bidding pages. You are asked to decide what bid/call you would make for the hand and when you have decided you click **BID** to go to the next page where the recommended bid is shown with any appropriate comments. This continues throughout the Bidding section, and when the final bid is made your partner's hand is also shown.

With both hands visible and the opening lead noted you are asked to make a Plan for each Deal. You should think this through just as if you were at the table. When you have the Plan in your mind, click **NEXT** to go to the next page.

All of the Notrump Plans include a Winner Count and all Suit Plans include a Loser Count.

During the Bidding section you are in the South position. As a result of that some of the Deals would end up with your partner North as the Declarer. When that happens a page will appear for you to click **ROTATE** to switch the hands so South becomes the Declarer. It is important to note that on this page the complete Bidding Auction is also rotated to correspond with South being Declarer. So if something in the plan depends upon the bidding this is the page to look at, not the earlier bidding pages.

The final page shows the full deal, including the East/West hands.

You may use the left Navigation panel to go to any numbered Deal you like, or you may just go to the next Deal by clicking the link at the bottom of the last page of a Deal.

ABOUT THE BIDDING

Normal 4-3-2-1 point count is used, with 1 length point added for any card more than 4 in any suit.

1NT Opening: 15-17 points

2NT Opening: 20-21 points

1NT Overcall: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers in their suit

2NT Overcall over a Weak 2-bid: 15-18 points, at least 1, (preferably 2), stoppers

Stayman convention is used extensively.

There is Stayman lesson on BakerBridge which can be reached by clicking Home on the menubar.

Jacoby Transfers are used extensively.

In addition to the standard 2♦ transfer to ♥ and 2♥ transfer to ♠ we also use a 2♠ transfer to 3♣.

There is a Jacoby Transfer lesson you can access by clicking Home.

The **lebensohl** convention is used when opponents overcall your side's 1NT opening.

Since this is not a standard for many of you, a brief explanation/comment is given when it occurs.

There is a lebensohl lesson you can access by clicking Home.

You can go either go through the deals in order, or use the Navigation Bar at left.

A collection of playing cards from a standard deck. On the left, a vertical stack of cards shows the hearts suit: Queen, Jack, 9, 7, 5, 2, and a single heart. In the center, a vertical stack shows the clubs suit: 8, a fan of 2 through 7, and a single club. To the right, a vertical stack shows the diamonds suit: 6, 4, 2, and a single diamond. Further right, a vertical stack shows the spades suit: Ace, Jack, 6, and a fan of 9 through 10. A single spade is also visible at the bottom right.

Count Fast and Slow Losers				
				Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Count Sure Winners				
				Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

A collection of playing cards. On the left, four cards are stacked vertically: 10 of Clubs, 6 of Clubs, 4 of Clubs, and 3 of Clubs. In the center, the Ace of Diamonds is shown above a fan of cards. The fan includes the Ace of Clubs, King of Clubs, Queen of Clubs, Jack of Clubs, 10 of Clubs, 9 of Clubs, 8 of Diamonds, 6 of Diamonds, 3 of Diamonds, Ace of Spades, 7 of Spades, 4 of Spades, Ace of Hearts, 9 of Hearts, and 4 of Hearts. To the right of the fan, the 8 of Spades is shown above the King of Hearts. The King of Hearts is also shown with a small 'palm' logo in the top right corner.

Count Sure Winners				
				Total

Decide How to Develop Winners			
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play

Count Fast and Slow Losers				
				Total

Decide How to Reduce Losers			
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length

Board: 1

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥

Declarer: North

Board: 2

Dealer: **East**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: East

Board: 3

Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: South

Board: 4

Dealer: **West**

Contract: 5♦

Declarer: West

Board: 5

Dealer: **North**

Contract: 3NT

Declarer: North

Board 1

North Deals

None Vul

♠ T 9 7 2

♥ A 8

♦ T 8 3

♣ T 9 6 4

♠ K 4

♥ K T 4 3

♦ A 7 5

♣ K Q J 2



♠ Q 8 5 3

♥ 6

♦ K Q J 9

♣ A 7 5 3

♠ A J 6

♥ Q J 9 7 5 2

♦ 6 4 2

♣ 8

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

2♦

Pass

2♥

Pass

4♥

All Pass

4♥ by North

Loser List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 4

There is no reason to hold up. Besides, you have bigger problems to deal with.

After you take the ♦ A at trick one you have four fast losers staring you in the face the instant you lose the lead. So do you pull trumps now?

No, you dare not touch trumps yet - remember those 4 fast losers.

You cannot avoid the ♥ A and ♣ A, so you must get rid of one of the ♦ losers before you play trumps.

Win the ♦ A, play the ♠ K, then finesse the ♠ J. If the finesse works discard a ♦ on the ♠ A, then pull trumps. If the finesse fails you will go down 2 instead of 1.

You made it - on a 50% chance.

When the cards MUST lie in a particular way for the contract to be makeable, just assume that's the way they lie and go for it.

With 10 points and a 6-card ♥ suit you want to transfer. You say 2♦ and partner bids 2♥.

With 10 points and a 6-card ♥ suit you want to transfer. You say 2♦ and partner bids 2♥.

You know you want to play in ♥s since partner will have at least 2 of them. Your problem is whether to merely invite with 3♥ or go ahead and bid the game. Since partner has either 15, 16 or 17 points you should probably just bid 4♥. The worst thing that could happen is that partner would be playing game with only 25 points.

The contract would be 4♥ played by South.

North plays 4♥. East leads the ♦ K. Do you hold up or not?

Board 2

East Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 7 4 3
♥ A Q 7 2
♦ 7 5 3
♣ K 8 4

♠ A 6
♥ 6 3
♦ Q T 9 8 4
♣ Q J T 6



♠ Q J T 5
♥ K 5 4
♦ A K 6
♣ A 5 2

♠ K 9 8 2
♥ J T 9 8
♦ J 2
♣ 9 7 3

West	North	East	South
		1NT	Pass
2♣	Pass	2♠	Pass
2NT	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East

♠ Q. If North wins with a doubleton ♠ honor you will only be able to win 1 ♠ since South will sit there with ♠ A 9 or ♠ K 9 behind your ♠ J 10.

Instead, win the first trick in dummy and play a small ♠ toward the ♠ Q J 10. North will play low and South must take his ♠ honor. But you can win his return, enter dummy and play another ♠ toward your hand. If you are lucky, North will be forced to play an honor and you can toss your ♠ 5.

to see if you were lucky.

This plan, leading toward your ♠ holding twice, will succeed the majority of the time.

It only fails if South holds 4 or more ♠s headed by A K.

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

In response to partner's Stayman bid you show your 4-card ♠ suit. Partner now bids 2NT.

You may disagree with the Stayman bid on 3-4-3-3 distribution. In any case, 2NT is invitational, so with 17 points you say 3NT.

East plays 3NT. South leads the ♥ J.

Winner List: ♠ = 0 : ♥ = 3/4 : ♦ = 2 : ♣ = 2 :: Total = 7/8

South's ♥ J lead probably means ♥s won't be 3-3, so you will need to get 2 ♠ tricks.

Suppose you win the first trick and plunk down the ♠ Q. If North wins with a doubleton ♠ honor you will only be able to win 1 ♠ since South will sit there with ♠ A 9 or ♠ K 9 behind your ♠ J 10.

Board 3
 South Deals
 None Vul

♠ J 9 2
 ♥ J 8 5
 ♦ J T 4
 ♣ J 7 5 2

♠ 8 6 5
 ♥ K 7 2
 ♦ A Q 9
 ♣ T 6 4 3



♠ K Q T 3
 ♥ Q T 6 3
 ♦ K 7 5 2
 ♣ 8

♠ A 7 4
 ♥ A 9 4
 ♦ 8 6 3
 ♣ A K Q 9

West	North	East	South
			1NT
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			
3NT by South			

A square hand, no 4-card Major, and 9 points. This is the very hand that the book said to bid 2NT with. And when you do, partner says 3NT which you pass.

The contract would be 3NT played by North.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♣2. You must be living right, West gives you a trick with the opening lead.

Winner List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 2 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 4 :: Total = 8

You got a good break on the opening lead, now you need only one more winner. There is **NO CHANCE** of creating another winner in ♠s, ♥s or ♣s, so your second good break is that you know it will have to be ♦s.

You **COULD** lead toward dummy's ♦Q, finessing West for the ♦K. That would be a perfectly good 50% chance. But there is an even better play if you look carefully.

Play a ♦ from your hand and if West plays low insert the ♦9. Much of the time East will win with the ♦J or ♦10. If so you are no worse off, you play West for the ♦K. But if it happens that West was dealt both the ♦J and ♦10 then East will have to win that trick with the ♦K, or perhaps not even win it at all!

As you see, the Deep Finesse of the ♦9 pays off here, where the straightforward finesse of the ♦Q would lose the contract. Two chances are definitely better than one.

But what if West has played the ♦10, splitting his honors?

You would put on dummy's ♦Q and East would win the ♦K. But you aren't down yet! Later you lead another ♦ toward dummy's ♦A 9 and finesse West for the ♦J.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ A 8 4
♥ A J 3
♦ Q T 6 5
♣ A K Q

♠ Q J T 9 3

♥ K 7 6 4

♦ A

♣ J T 3



♠ K 7 6 2

♥ 5

♦ K J 8 7 4 3

♣ 7 2

♠ 5

♥ Q T 9 8 2

♦ 9 2

♣ 9 8 6 5 4

West	North	East	South
2NT	Pass	3♣	Pass
3♦	Pass	4♦	Pass
5♦			
All Pass			

5♦ by West

This looks so easy let's check it by trying a winner count as well. Five ♦s (after ♦A is gone), the ♠ A K, the ♥A and the ♣ A K Q. Yes that adds up to 11 winners.

Is there ANY danger here at all?

Whenever a hand looks easy you should ask yourself what could go wrong. And here the only thing that could go wrong is if one of your ♠ winners gets ruffed. So how can you prevent that possibility?

If South has a singleton ♠, and North has the ♦A you might go down if you win the first trick in your hand. North will take his ♦A and play the ♠J. If you go up with dummy's ♠K South will ruff and you will still have a ♠ loser.

The simple solution is to win the first trick with dummy's ♠K. Now when North wins the ♦A and leads another ♠ it's a different situation. South may well ruff, but if he does you will just play a low card - South will have ruffed your ♠ **LOSER**.

You are a little unlucky that South has a singleton ♠.

But you are very lucky that you took the time to read this hand so you know how to play safely!

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 3♦. Partner now bids 4♦.

Partner's 3♣ bid is Stayman; with no 4-card Major you respond 3♦. Partner now bids 4♦.

Partner wouldn't bypass 3NT unless he was pretty distributional. His bid is invitational and you have excellent ♦ help so you try 5♦.

West plays 5♦. North leads the ♠Q.

You may be wishing partner had said 3NT. But at 3NT North might have led a ♥, then you'd be wishing you were in 5♦.

Loser List: ♠ = 1 : ♥ = 0 : ♦ = 1 : ♣ = 0 :: Total = 2

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ T 9 5 4

♥ J 8

♦ 9 5 3

♣ T 9 6 5

♠ A J 6

♥ A Q 5 4

♦ K Q 8 2

♣ 7 3



♠ Q 7

♥ K T 9 2

♦ 7 6

♣ K Q J 8 2

♠ K 8 3 2

♥ 7 6 3

♦ A J T 4

♣ A 4

West

North

East

South

1NT

Pass

2♣

Pass

2♥

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by North
you hold up or not?

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

You have 12 points and a 4-card ♠ suit. To find a possible 4-4 fit you bid 2♣, the Stayman convention. Partner bids 2♥.

You were hoping for a ♠ response, but so be it. You now bid 3NT, knowing partner will correct to 4♠ if he was 4-4 in the Majors, or pass if he doesn't have 4 ♠s. He passes.

The contract would be 3NT played by South.

North plays 3NT.

East leads the ♣K, West follows with the ♣T. Do

Winner List: ♠ = 2 : ♥ = 1 : ♦ = 4 : ♣ = 1 :: Total = 8

It makes no difference whether you hold up or not, (unless their ♣s are 7-2), so go ahead and take the first trick.

Either the ♥Q or the ♠J **MIGHT** become your ninth trick.

If you try either finesse and it wins you will make your contract. If you try either finesse and it loses you will be set immediately with ♣s. Each finesse is a 50% shot.

Is there anything you can do to improve your chances?

Of course - otherwise the question wouldn't have been asked! You can combine two chances. Obviously you cannot take both finesses, but you can try to drop the ♠Q in two pulls, and if she doesn't drop you still have the ♥ finesse to fall back on. So win the ♣A, play 4 ♦ winners and the ♠ A K, then see whether you have to try the ♥ finesse.

Aha - the ♠Q dropped so you take your 9 tricks.

But if she hadn't, you'd still have a 50% chance in ♥s.